

NOTE FOR THE FILE

Continuation of the Data and Information Team Activities

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With less than two months to run on my contract, I need clear vision of the future of the Data and Information Team. Following extensive discussions with the main stakeholders in Nairobi and Addis, I have come to these views:

1. The D&I Information team activities should be integrated into the proposed HAIC (now referred to as “Data Warehouse”) in Nairobi, as soon as possible
2. If OCHA is to maintain an operational stake in the warehouse (it already has a policy/managerial stake through the participation of Pat Banks and Fernando on the Steering Committee) it must fund at least a transitional period.

Point 1: Hosting

The database development activities of the D&I Team are an integral part of the information coordination functions, services, and physical structure of the proposed warehouse. This is clear from the project proposal, the project document, and the “statement of intent” that emerged from the first HAIC consultation in January/February 2001. All my work on preparing the groundwork for the warehouse has been geared towards finding the appropriate institutional environment for the continuation of the D&I activities in an inter-agency setting, in the knowledge that the ORHC is only a temporary arrangement with a limited mandate.

As a general point, the UN is moving towards greater harmonization of its activities. A jointly owned facility should be a high profile “flagship” project, demonstrating the capability of UN agencies to work together. The case for harmonization of data activities came out of the Nairobi consultation.

Nairobi has several advantages over Addis Ababa, which I have referred to before. These include:

- Ease of travel and communications within the region
- The physical facilities that have been offered by UNEP
- The presence of several donor, UN, and NGO regional offices in Nairobi, as well as Kenya, Southern Sudan, and Somalia offices
- Addis based activities tend to be overly Ethiopia centered, alienating the other countries

There is an additional question mark: Who would host in Addis Ababa? UNEUE does not have a regional mandate and Gromo has suggested that EUE would not be willing to take it on. The ORHC, whether it continues or not, has a limited geographical and subject focus.

The Warehouse project is advancing at a satisfactory pace. We now have:

- Two part-time international staff working on establishing the facility in Nairobi
- The physical facility (hosting) provided by UNEP
- A website (domain registered, contents under development)
- Several sample GIS and remote sensing products
- An established steering committee (first meeting today)
- An agreement from UNOPS to act as implementing agency (to be confirmed during SC)
- Substantial interest from several donors
- Buy in from the all the main donors and UN agencies, and substantial NGO interest

It is nonsense to try to maintain a separate activity in Addis.

Point 2: The Transition Period

In order to ensure a smooth transition, there is a need of a period of at least two months to establish the D&I team structures in Nairobi. I suggest that the phase-out phase-in should be from mid June 2001 to mid August 2001. I am contracted until July 9th 2001, so will need an additional month to ensure the transition. I also propose that Lakew Legesse and Dagne Berecha spend some time in Nairobi, to help with the smooth set up of the critical systems.

It is essential for OCHA to ensure that it has an operational stake in the project, not least because the warehouse will provide very useful services to the national units. My personal belief is that OCHA can enhance its profile in the Horn only by supporting inter-agency initiatives of this kind, rather than attempting to establish its own institutional structures. Unless, of course, OCHA wants to go down the primrose path of DHA and UNDRO...

After today's meeting of the warehouse steering committee, the project document will be submitted to donors. We are expecting a strong response. OCHA should take immediate steps to gain a foothold, by financing the phase-in of the D&I activities. We are at an advanced stage in the development of core applications. This work will be wasted if transitional financing arrangements are not made, and quickly.

Obtaining transitional finance is high priority. I am very unsure that we should attempt to go out to donors for reimbursement of the team's expenses for activities up to mid 2001. A proposal of this kind will probably jeopardize the chances of getting funding for the continuation of the activities. I would appreciate a clear explanation as to why it is necessary to reimburse ORHC.

Actions

In the coming weeks, I suggest the following actions at managerial level:

- **Rephrase the draft report on the Nairobi consultation**, which is too vague: *The Database/Information Coordination project of ORHC ~~may~~ will be transferred to the HAIC project ~~at the end of ORHC, at which time~~ and applications that are currently being developed ~~may~~ will be incorporated in the HAIC project.* Suggest circulation of revised document in the form of a strategy paper (Yvon)
- **Obtain consensus from NY and Geneva** on the transition, through a clearly-worded letter and supporting document for Ed Tsui and Ross Mountain, advocating for OCHA support for the warehouse project (Ben and Bronek)
- **Pressure OCHA NY to provide funds for the transitional period**, in the region of USD 30000. We should also attempt to ensure that OCHA maintains an operational stake, possibly through the funding of one of the two international posts. (Pablo, Ben, and Bronek)
- **Follow up with UNDP NY on regional resources** of the Africa and Arab States Bureaus, as discussed in the Nairobi consultation, to obtain seed money for the “warehouse” (Bronek and Randolph)